

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

Costa Rican Peppermint / Jamaican Tree Mint Grow Guide

For the small-leaf woody tree mint - not French thyme/Cuban oregano

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Customer Grow Guide

Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Likely Cause	What To Do First
Leaves wilt and soil is wet	Root stress, poor drainage, or overwatering	Move to bright shade, check drainage, let top 1 inch dry before watering.
Leaves crisp or brown at edges	Dry pot, intense sun, wind stress	Water deeply, move to morning sun/afternoon shade, mulch lightly.
Plant gets tall with bare stems	Not enough pruning or low light	Cut back tips by 1/3; give brighter light.
Tiny insects/sticky leaves	Aphids, whiteflies, mealybugs	Spray undersides and stem joints; repeat every 3-5 days.
Fine webbing or speckled leaves	Spider mites	Rinse leaves, prune damage, avoid drought stress.
Black or brown leaf spots	Leaf spot or wet foliage disease	Remove affected leaves; improve airflow; water at soil level.
Stem base soft or rotten	Soil too wet or poor drainage	Repot in well-draining mix; reduce watering.
Weak aroma	Old woody growth or too much shade	Prune for fresh growth; give brighter light.

Quick Numbers

Item	Target / Range
Likely botanical name	Satureja viminea / Micromeria viminea / Clinopodium vimineum
Common local names	Costa Rican peppermint, Jamaican mint tree, Jamaican mint bush, bush mint
Growth habit	Woody or semi-woody upright mint-family shrub
Leaf size	Small leaves, commonly about 0.5-2.5 cm long in technical descriptions
Plant height	About 3 ft commonly; can become 5-10 ft shrub/small tree in tropical conditions if unpruned
Sunlight	Full sun to part shade; best customer setting is morning sun plus bright shade in hot areas
Water	Regular water, but soil must drain well
Container	Start 4-6 inch plants in 1 gallon; larger plants need 3-5 gallon or bigger
Pruning	Pinch/cut every 2-4 weeks in active growth to keep bushy
Harvest	Cut leafy tips, not old bare wood; harvest lightly after transplanting

Identification note: this is not French thyme/Cuban oregano. French thyme/Cuban oregano has larger, thicker, fuzzy/succulent leaves. This guide is for the small-leaf, woody Costa Rican peppermint/Jamaican tree mint type.

Identification and Differences

Plant	How to Identify It	Growing Difference
Costa Rican Peppermint / Jamaican Tree Mint	Small glossy leaves; narrow where leaf meets stem, wider toward rounded/curved tip; upright woody stems; strong mint aroma.	Prune like a small shrub. Keep in well-drained soil with regular water.
Peppermint / Black Mint	True Mentha mint; spreading runners/rhizomes; darker leaves/stems; cooling peppermint smell.	Keep contained in pots; harvest runners and tips often.
Spearmint	True Mentha mint; spreading runners; pointed/crinkled leaves; sweet spearmint smell.	Similar to peppermint but often more heat tolerant.
French Thyme / Cuban Oregano	Large thick/fuzzy succulent-like leaves; oregano/thymey smell; broad leaves.	Different plant; handles dryness differently; not this guide.

Because local names vary, confirm by smell, leaf size, stem habit, and customer/local source before using it as food or tea.

Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Need	Target
Sunlight	Full sun to part shade. In hot areas, use morning sun and afternoon shade.
Soil	Well-drained soil. Neutral to slightly alkaline soil is often recommended.
Water	Regular water, but never keep the root zone soggy.
Pot drainage	Drainage holes required. Do not leave pot sitting in water.
Airflow	Good airflow helps prevent leaf spots and stem rot.
Mulch	Light mulch is helpful, but keep it away from the stem base.

- For small customer pots, check moisture daily in hot weather.
- If the plant wilts in the afternoon but recovers by morning, it may need shade or a larger pot.
- If it wilts all day while soil is wet, check drainage and roots.

Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	Feeding
After transplant	10-14 days after planting	Light feed only if plant has settled and is growing.
Active growth	Every 4-6 weeks	Topdress with compost or use light balanced feed.
After pruning/harvest	3-7 days after cutting	Water well; feed lightly if new growth is slow.
Stressed plant	When wilted, yellowing, or wet	Do not fertilize until water/drainage problem is fixed.

Do not overfeed. Too much fertilizer can make soft weak growth and reduce aroma quality.

Harvesting Guide

Use	When to Harvest	How to Harvest
Tea/kitchen leaf harvest	When tips are leafy and plant is actively growing	Cut soft leafy tips 3-6 inches long.
Bush shaping	Every 2-4 weeks in active growth	Pinch tips or cut stems back by 1/3.
Larger harvest	When plant is full and healthy	Take no more than 1/3 of plant at once.
After transplant	First 2 weeks	Avoid heavy harvest; let roots settle.

- Harvest in the morning after leaves dry.
- Use clean scissors/pruners.
- Regular tip harvesting keeps the plant compact and leafy.

Leaf Color Problem Guide

Leaf Look	Possible Cause	Action
Glossy green, firm leaves	Healthy growth	Continue regular water and pruning.
Pale leaves	Low nutrients, too much shade, root stress	Increase light, check drainage, feed lightly.
Yellow leaves	Overwatering, old leaves, root issue	Reduce watering if wet; prune old leaves.
Brown edges	Dry pot, hot sun, salt/fertilizer stress	Water deeply, shade afternoon, flush pot if overfed.
Black/brown spots	Leaf spot or water sitting on leaves	Remove spotted leaves; water soil only.
Small weak new growth	Root-bound pot or nutrient shortage	Repot to larger container or feed lightly.

Flowering, Woody Stems, and Pruning

Pruning

- This plant should be pruned like a small herb shrub.
- Pinch soft tips every 2-4 weeks to keep it full.
- Do not keep cutting only the same side; shape the whole plant.
- Avoid cutting all the way into old bare wood unless plant is strong.

Woody Stems

- Woody stems are normal as the plant matures.
- If the plant gets bare at the bottom, prune gradually and let new shoots fill in.
- For customer pots, shift to a larger pot before the plant becomes root-bound.

Small Farmer Notes

- Grow mother plants in well-drained beds or 3-5 gallon pots.
- Space shrubs about 2-3 ft apart for hand harvest and airflow.
- Harvest leafy tips in light batches every 2-4 weeks.
- Keep mother plants pruned and clean for future cuttings.
- Do not overwater production plants; root disease is easier to prevent than fix.
- Label clearly as Costa Rican Peppermint / Jamaican Tree Mint - not French thyme.

Home Garden Notes

- For 1-3 plants, grow in pots where the customer can manage water and pruning.
- Start small plants in 1 gallon pots; move larger plants to 3-5 gallon pots.
- Use morning sun with afternoon shade if leaves burn.
- Prune tips often for tea/kitchen use and a bushy shape.
- Do not let the pot stay in a saucer of water.

Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

- Wash hands before handling plants, especially after handling diseased plants or tobacco/cigarettes.
- Use clean scissors for harvest and pruning.
- Do not take cuttings from plants with leaf spots, mites, or mealybugs.
- Keep pot surfaces clean by removing fallen leaves.
- When propagating, use clean pots and well-drained medium.

Clean handling is especially important if plants are being sold to customers as starter plants.

Hardening Off Before Planting

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade for 2-3 hours.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 2-4 hours.
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus bright afternoon shade.
Day 7	Ready to transplant, repot, or place in final position.

- Keep root ball moist during hardening off.
- If leaves wilt badly, return plant to shade and water gently.
- Do not move shade-grown plants straight to full hot sun.

Transplanting From Small Pots

- Water the plant 1-2 hours before transplanting.
- Prepare a well-draining potting mix before removing the plant.
- Move 4-6 inch sale plants into 1 gallon pots if the customer wants steady harvest.
- Keep the root ball together.
- Plant at the same depth as the original pot.
- Water after transplanting and keep in bright shade for 1-2 days.
- Do not fertilize heavily right after transplanting.

Planting Situation	Spacing / Pot Size
Small starter plant	1 gallon pot after purchase if growing for harvest.
Home container	3-5 gallon pot for longer-term bush.
Garden bed	2-3 ft apart for airflow and harvest access.
Small farmer mother plants	2-3 ft apart or individual 3-5 gallon pots.

Common Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Mealybugs	White cottony clusters on stem joints and leaf nodes	Wipe off small groups; prune bad areas; repeat treatment.
Aphids	Soft insects on new growth; sticky leaves	Spray off and use mild soap solution; repeat 3-5 days.
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects under leaves	Spray undersides; use yellow sticky traps.
Spider mites	Fine webbing, speckled dry leaves	Rinse leaves; prune damage; avoid drought stress.
Scale insects	Small bumps on stems/leaves; sticky residue	Prune heavily infested parts; wipe stems; monitor new growth.

Common Diseases

Disease	Signs	Action
Root rot	Wilting with wet soil; black/brown roots; sour smell	Improve drainage; reduce watering; repot into fresh mix.
Leaf spot	Brown/black spots on leaves	Remove affected leaves; water soil only; improve airflow.
Stem rot	Soft dark stem base	Remove affected stems; reduce moisture; repot if needed.
Powdery mildew	White powdery coating	Improve airflow; prune crowded growth; avoid wet leaves.

Sources and Support

Need help with your plant? Send clear photos of the full plant, damaged leaves, underside of leaves, soil/pot, and any insects you see.

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Source notes used to prepare this customer guide:

- CARDI/IICA technical manual for production of specific herbal plants in Jamaica: identifies Jamaican mint bush/Satureja viminea as naturalized in the West Indies and describes glossy lime-green oval leaves about 0.5-2.5 cm long.
- Puerto Rico CUPCC Costa Rican Mint Bush profile: lists Jamaican Peppermint, Satureja/Micromeria viminea, and recommends well-drained to dry, neutral to alkaline soil in sun.
- Herb Society of America: describes Jamaican mint/Costa Rican mint bush as a shrubby tender perennial tropical plant commonly around 3 ft high.
- RHS Satureja viminea profile: describes Satureja plants as aromatic subshrubs/perennials with linear to obovate leaves and summer tubular flowers.
- Top Tropicals and nursery profiles: describe Satureja viminea/Jamaican Mint Tree as suitable for full sun to semi-shade, regular water, and shrub/small-tree growth in tropical conditions.